

FAI Governance for Asymmetric Selves

Derivation Note D2.47 | Series D, Note #542

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This work derives from and formalizes the inter-Self coordination architecture introduced in “Inter-Self Coordination via Shared Substrate / Full Aspect Integration” (Li, April 2026), the third paper in the CKS theory series following “Coordination Outside the Model: A Human-Governed Substrate Pattern for AI Systems” (Li, April 2026) and “The Instinct/Reasoning Separation Outside the Model” (Li, April 2026).

Abstract

Paper 3 makes no assumption that CKS-governed Selves participating in Full Aspect Integration (FAI) events have equivalent governance architectures. This note formalizes the governance asymmetry case as an operational decomposition of D1.07 (n-ary cardinality) and D2.37 (FAI minimum viable governance). Four asymmetry types arise in practice: governance depth, evolution feed capacity, governance capacity, and governance maturity. The architecture accommodates each through four calibration mechanisms: the minimum viable governance floor applies equally to all participants regardless of sophistication; sharing scope configuration (D1.22 Dimension 1) reflects each Self’s actual contribution capacity; orchestration rules are calibrated to the simpler Self’s governance capacity; and evolution feed configuration reflects each Self’s actual evolution machinery. Governance asymmetry is a governance trust calibration input (D2.29), not a disqualification. The anti-pattern—requiring governance symmetry as a participation prerequisite—forecloses adoption by organizations whose governance architectures are simpler but valid. The minimum viable floor is the only participation requirement the architecture imposes.

1. The asymmetry case

D1.07 establishes FAI as an n-ary operation: two or more CKS-governed Selves each contribute aspects to a shared substrate constructed for the duration of an inter-Self event. The n-ary cardinality commitment does not require that participating Selves have equivalent governance architectures. A FAI event between Self A with a three-level, richly-governed architecture and Self B with a minimal-but-compliant governance structure is architecturally valid from D1.07’s standpoint,

because the cardinality commitment specifies how many participants contribute, not the depth or sophistication of each participant's home-perimeter governance.

D2.37 establishes the minimum viable governance floor: a seven-requirement set that any Self must satisfy to participate in FAI events. The floor is a necessary and sufficient participation requirement. It is not a threshold that scales with governance sophistication, and it does not vary based on the governance architecture of the other participants in a given event.

D2.47 sits at the intersection of these two commitments. It formalizes what governance asymmetry means in practice, what forms it takes, and how the architecture accommodates it without requiring symmetric participation. The derivation is operational: it converts D1.07's cardinality neutrality and D2.37's floor universality into concrete configuration guidance for FAI events between Selves with significantly different governance architectures.

2. Four asymmetry types

Type 1 — Governance depth. A governance-deep Self has a multi-level architecture: many cells, multiple aspects with rich DNA-layer content, full Self integration, and governance that operates coherently across all levels. A governance-shallow Self has fewer cells, minimal aspect structure, and basic governance that nonetheless meets the minimum viable floor. The governance-deep Self can contribute elaborated aspects with DNA-layer content reflecting accumulated decisions, rationale, and constraints authored and maintained over a sustained governance history. The governance-shallow Self contributes simpler aspects whose DNA content is less dense but remains governed and valid. The asymmetry here is not a deficit in the shallower Self—both Selves meet the floor—but a difference in the richness of what each has to contribute.

Type 2 — Evolution feed capacity. A Self with active directed selection governance conducts regular DNA evolution cycles: post-event review, selection among variant DNA-layer content, and deliberate refinement of its cells' coordination patterns. This Self can absorb DNA-layer content from FAI events through the DNA evolution locus (D2.11), because it has the governance machinery to evaluate, select among, and integrate what it receives. A Self that rarely or never conducts directed selection does not have that machinery. For such a Self, the action-feedback locus (D2.10) is the more realistic absorption path: it records what happened at the action layer without requiring the governance overhead that DNA evolution demands. The asymmetry here is between the two loci's home-governance requirements, not between the Selves' floor compliance.

Type 3 — Governance capacity. A Self with dedicated governance practitioners can handle complex orchestration rules, multi-step conflict resolution workflows, and elaborate escalation paths. It has people whose primary responsibility is to govern—to write rules, review post-mortems, authorize resolutions, and maintain the governance architecture over time. A Self whose governance is conducted by operational staff alongside primary work has a different capacity ceiling. For a FAI event to be executable, the conflict resolution rules (D2.15) must be within both Selves' governance

capacity to authorize and apply. Rules calibrated to the more sophisticated Self's capacity may be ungovernable by the operational-staff-governed Self. Rules calibrated to the lower capacity remain executable for both.

Type 4 — Governance maturity. A Self that has conducted FAI events for several years has accumulated post-mortems (D2.39), refined its standing configurations (D2.21) based on experience, and developed an operational history that its governance practitioners can reason about and learn from. A Self conducting its first FAI events has no such history. The maturity asymmetry affects not just the richness of configurations but the confidence with which governance decisions can be made: the mature Self can point to prior events and documented resolutions; the new Self cannot. This does not disqualify the new Self from participating. It means that its governance trust calibration (D2.29) starts at a lower level, with sharing scope and provenance depth configurations reflecting that starting position.

3. Four architecture accommodations

Accommodation 1 — The minimum viable floor applies to both. D2.37's seven floor requirements apply identically to every FAI participant, regardless of how sophisticated or simple its overall governance architecture is. A Self that meets the floor is a compliant participant. A Self that does not meet the floor is a non-participant, regardless of how sophisticated a potential partner might be. The floor is the entry criterion; it is universal and non-negotiable; and it does not scale upward to match a richer partner's governance depth. This universality is the architecture's inclusion principle: the design does not exclude simpler governance architectures from participation. It ensures that the participation criterion is governed—the floor is specified, inspectable, and verifiable—while remaining achievable by organizations that are beginning their governance journey.

Accommodation 2 — Sharing scope reflects each Self's actual contribution capacity. D1.22 Dimension 1—sharing scope—specifies which aspects a Self contributes to the shared substrate for a given FAI event. The sharing scope configuration is per-Self and per-event. A governance-deep Self with many elaborated aspects may configure a rich sharing scope that offers multiple aspects with dense DNA-layer content. A governance-shallow Self may configure a sharing scope that offers a single basic aspect. Asymmetric sharing scope is architecturally valid: FAI does not require equivalent contributions from all participants. The architecture accommodates heterogeneous contribution depth as a design feature, not as a deviation to be corrected. The practical consequence is that the simpler Self contributes what it has, the richer Self contributes what it has, and both contributions enter the shared substrate as governed aspects under the full-merge-as-default commitment.

Accommodation 3 — Orchestration rules calibrated to the simpler Self's governance capacity. For the conflict resolution tier of three-tier conflict handling (D2.15) to be operative, the

orchestration rules governing resolution must be within both Selves' governance capacity to authorize and apply. If one Self has dedicated governance practitioners and the other has operational staff performing governance alongside primary work, rules designed for the practitioner-governed Self may require expertise and bandwidth the operational-staff-governed Self cannot reliably supply. Rules should be calibrated to the governance capacity of the least-capable participant. This is a constraint on the shared rules that govern the inter-Self event, not on how sophisticated the more capable Self's home-perimeter governance can be. Standing configurations (D2.21) are particularly useful for governance-asymmetric events: pre-authorized responses that do not require case-by-case deliberation reduce the in-event governance burden for the less-capable Self without requiring the more capable Self to operate below its normal governance register.

Accommodation 4 — Evolution feed configuration reflects each Self's actual evolution capacity. The four-locus evolution feed mechanism (D2.10, D2.11) connects FAI event outcomes to each Self's home-perimeter evolution machinery. The DNA evolution locus is most valuable when the receiving Self has active directed selection governance, because DNA-layer content from a FAI event can only be meaningfully absorbed if the receiving Self has the governance process to evaluate and select among it. For a Self that lacks directed selection, the DNA evolution locus adds configuration overhead without producing absorption value. The evolution feed configuration for governance-asymmetric events should reflect this difference: the more capable Self configures for DNA evolution locus absorption where it has the machinery; the less capable Self configures primarily for action-feedback locus absorption, which does not require directed selection governance. The per-perimeter asymmetric ingestion property (D1.21) is precisely what makes this accommodation architecturally coherent—ingestion is configured per home-perimeter governance, not as a uniform broadcast to all participants.

4. Asymmetry as governance trust calibration input

D2.29 establishes governance trust calibration as the mechanism by which a Self's track record, demonstrated governance quality, and history of FAI participation shape the sharing scope and provenance depth configurations for events involving that Self. Governance asymmetry is a direct input to this calibration.

A Self with limited governance maturity—conducting its first FAI events, with no post-mortem history and no accumulated standing configurations—starts at a calibrated trust level that reflects what can be verified about it: that it meets the minimum viable floor (D2.37), and nothing more. The sharing scope configuration for that Self in early events may be narrower than what a partner would configure for a mature, track-record-bearing counterpart.

This calibration is dynamic. Each FAI event produces post-mortem content (D2.39) that is available as governance evidence for subsequent calibration decisions. A Self that begins with minimal maturity and a narrow sharing scope can accumulate track record through conducted events,

documented resolutions, and demonstrated governance quality. The calibration for subsequent events can reflect this accumulated evidence, expanding sharing scope and provenance depth as confidence grows.

The governance trust calibration mechanism therefore converts governance asymmetry from a binary participation question—is the simpler Self allowed in?—into a configuration question: what sharing scope, provenance depth, and orchestration rules are appropriate given what is known about this Self’s governance track record? The answer to the participation question is determined by the floor. The answer to the configuration question is determined by the calibration. Keeping these two questions distinct is what prevents governance asymmetry from being either a disqualification or a blank permission.

5. Anti-pattern: the governance symmetry requirement

The governance symmetry requirement is the disposition that FAI participants should have equivalent governance architectures before participating—that a governance-deep Self should not engage in FAI with a governance-shallow Self, or that a governance-mature organization should require its FAI partners to reach a matching governance level before events can proceed.

This anti-pattern misreads the architecture in two directions simultaneously.

First, it reads the floor as a moving target. D2.37’s floor is a fixed specification: seven requirements, universally applied, not scaled by partner sophistication. The governance symmetry requirement effectively replaces the floor with a match condition—a different and more restrictive criterion that the architecture does not impose. A simpler Self that meets the floor is compliant by architectural specification. A governance symmetry requirement overrides that specification with a standard the architecture does not recognize.

Second, it forecloses graduated adoption. If organizations with simpler governance architectures cannot participate until they match their partners’ sophistication, they have no path into FAI experience. FAI experience is precisely what produces the post-mortem content, standing configuration refinement, and governance track record that calibrate toward richer participation over time. An entry requirement of symmetry removes the mechanism by which simpler organizations would develop toward sophistication. The architecture’s design enables the reverse: floor compliance plus calibrated configuration lets a governance-new Self participate, accumulate event history, and improve its governance architecture through experience. The path from simpler to more sophisticated governance runs through conducted events, not through a pre-participation equivalence gate.

The accommodation for governance asymmetry is not a relaxation of the architecture’s standards. The floor is non-negotiable and universal. The governance trust calibration is accurate, not permissive: it reflects what is verifiable, not what is claimed. Orchestration rules calibrated to lower

governance capacity are appropriate constraints, not lowered standards. The anti-pattern conflates “architecturally accommodating” with “architecturally permissive without constraint,” which is not the accommodation the architecture provides.

6. Operational test

For a FAI event between Selves with significantly different governance architectures, an observer can verify:

1. Both Selves meet the minimum viable governance floor (D2.37). A simpler Self’s floor compliance is verified against the same seven requirements as a more sophisticated Self’s. Neither a simpler Self’s floor compliance nor a more sophisticated partner’s governance depth changes this verification criterion.
2. The sharing scope configuration (D1.22 Dimension 1) for each Self reflects what that Self actually has to contribute—not an aspirational scope that exceeds its governed aspect inventory, and not a symmetry-imposed scope that requires it to match its partner’s contribution depth.
3. The orchestration rules governing conflict resolution (D2.15) are within the governance capacity of both Selves to authorize and apply. Where governance capacities differ, the rules are calibrated to the less-capable Self.
4. The evolution feed configuration for each Self (D2.10, D2.11) reflects that Self’s actual evolution machinery: a Self without active directed selection governance is configured for action-feedback locus absorption; a Self with active directed selection governance may additionally configure for DNA evolution locus absorption.
5. The governance trust calibration (D2.29) for the governance-asymmetric Self is based on verifiable evidence—floor compliance plus accumulated track record from prior events—not on aspirational claims about governance quality not yet demonstrated.

A FAI event between governance-asymmetric Selves that passes all five verification points is architecturally valid and operationally governed. A FAI event that requires participants to demonstrate governance symmetry before it can proceed is applying the anti-pattern identified in §5.

7. Conclusion

Governance asymmetry is a normal condition in n-ary FAI. The architecture’s response is not to require symmetric participation but to specify the floor universally, calibrate configurations to actual governance capacity, and convert asymmetry from a binary admission question into a configuration calibration input. The four asymmetry types—governance depth, evolution feed capacity, governance capacity, and governance maturity—each have direct architecture accommodations: universal floor, asymmetric sharing scope, rule calibration to the less-capable participant, and per-perimeter evolution feed configuration. The governance trust calibration

mechanism ensures that asymmetric partnerships are accurately configured, not permissively unconfigured. The governance symmetry requirement anti-pattern is the misreading that mistakes accurate accommodation for an absence of standards.

Source papers

Li, W. (2026a). *Coordination Outside the Model: A Human-Governed Substrate Pattern for AI Systems*. April 2026. ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235.

Li, W. (2026b). *The Instinct/Reasoning Separation Outside the Model*. April 2026. ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235.

Li, W. (2026c). *Inter-Self Coordination via Shared Substrate / Full Aspect Integration*. April 2026. ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235.

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